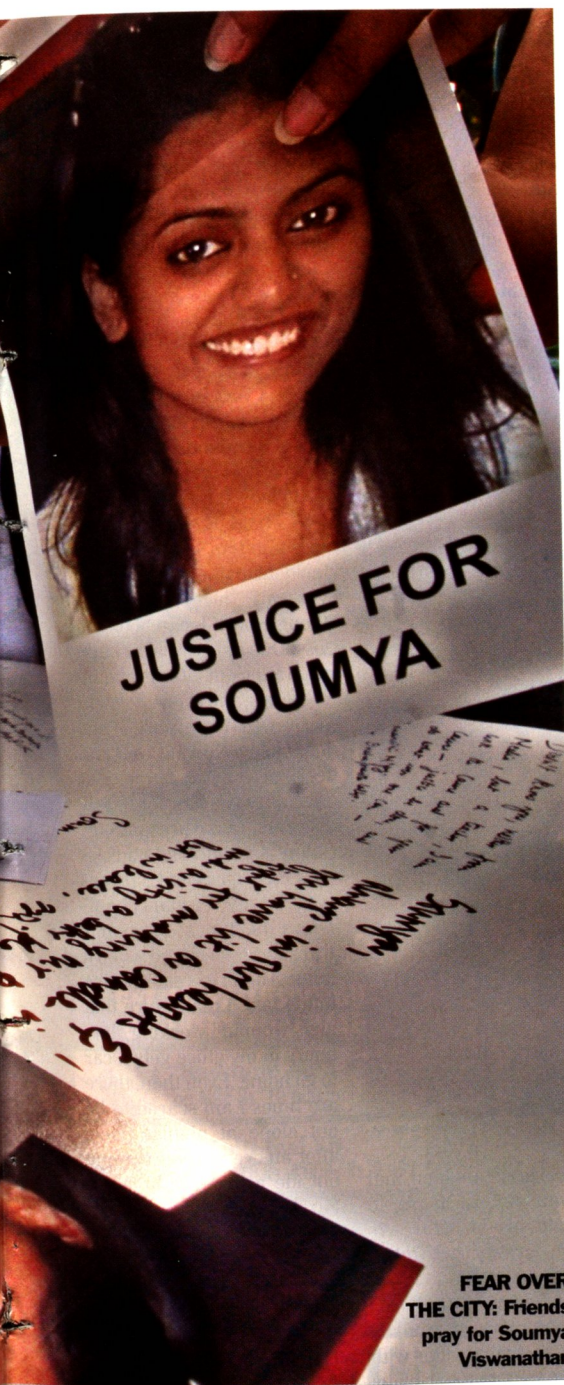




75%

registered cases where the offenders were known to the victims. Over 36 per cent of these were neighbours.

National Crime Records Bureau data, till 2006

“While the physical wounds healed, it was harder to recover from the mental trauma.”

It was October 2, 2004. I still remember the date. I completed my work around 10 p.m., something not late by Mumbai standards. I thought I'd meet a friend for dinner before heading home. The city had been home to me for four years now, and I didn't even think twice about sitting on the edge of the autorickshaw seat as the driver pulled up at a traffic light near Andheri junction. Suddenly, there was a blur as a man in white shirt approached. Before I could realise what was happening, he attacked me with a razor-sharp object and slit open my wrist. When I looked down, even

was much harder to recover from the mental trauma that the incident had inflicted. I had chosen a career that required me to stay out late at night. I faced stiff resistance from my parents who stay in Pune, even my brave retired army officer father. Call me stubborn but I managed to convince them.

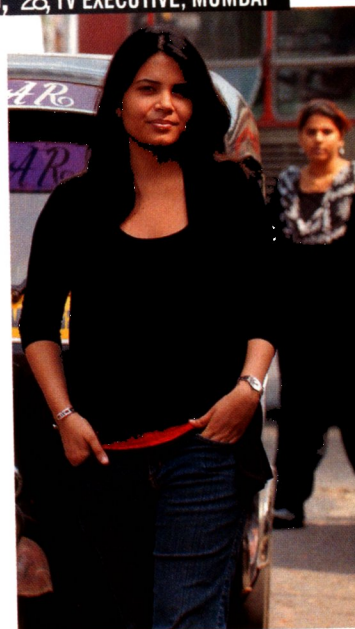
It's been four years now, but the fear and insecurity of being followed by the unknown still sends shivers down my spine. Mumbai may be touted as the safest metro but that does not hold true for me. Or indeed for others. Remember the policeman who was accused of raping a college girl at

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my shirt bore a cut near the shoulder. I was shocked.

The auto rickshaw driver pulled up speed and took me to my friend who waiting for me just five minutes away from the spot. The wound required four stitches. The next day, I went to the Andheri police station to register a complaint. They asked me to draw a rough sketch of the culprit but the incident had occurred so quickly I could not recollect his face. The police wanted to know if I had any professional rivalry with anyone. Me? I was just starting as an assistant. Another routine interrogation followed. They even called me twice to check if I had thought of a possible suspect. But they could do little without sufficient details about the culprit.

I took leave from work for two months but while the physical wounds healed, it



MANDAR DEODHAR

Marine Drive in 2005, or the incident when a woman was assaulted at the Gateway of India or even on New Year's Eve, when two women were